Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's Sonnet 100

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the **relationship between the speaker** in William Shakespeare's Sonnet 100 "[Where art thou, muse, that thou forget'st so long]" **and the muse** whom he addresses, however the concept muse is to be understood, including, perhaps, as the speaker's own imagination, include, **especially in terms of diction choice**,

alliteration,	eternizing/immortalizing,	numbers,
apostrophe,	hyperbole,	paragoge,
assonance,	iambic pentameter,	personification,
chiasmus,	imagination,	rhetorical question,
consonance,	inversion,	rhyme scheme,
diction,	lay,	sigmatism,
elision,	metonymy,	simile, and
epenthesis,	muse,	tone.

The strong response should note the shifts (notably subtle) in the speaker's tone while he addresses, (perhaps cajoles) his muse: "Where art thou" (fairly neutral); "Spend'st how thy fury" (sarcastic); "Return, forgetful Muse" (placating); "Rise, resty Muse" (accusatory); "be a satire" and "make Time's spoils" (commanding); "Give my love" (invoking). The young writer might approach their analysis-becomes-discussion through a *Handbook* understanding of the concept muse and her (classically defined) "responsibility. **This approach more than suffices.**

Either or both a familiarity with post-classical literature (and other artistic expression) or a close read will have the LitCritter recognizing the speaker-as-poet's use of *muse* is in terms of the speaker's own imagination or poetic talent—not the supernaturally-sourced divine afflatus so long in vogue. Thus any recognition that the first quatrain's rhetorical questions should—not must—point to the speaker's effectively addressing himself, which might preclude the sonnet's being an apostrophe; however . . . .

The competitor should address the speaker's seeking inspiration and his chiding his muse for wasting time on poetry ("song" line 3) that celebrates something of lesser worth than the most deserving object of the speaker-as-poet's interrupted flow of praise (see closing couplet). The speaker, however, might be losing interest in this particular object of praise and is choosing to blame his imagination.

The tonal shift in diction choice, the young writer might note, progresses through the poem (see first paragraph) toward a classically phrased invocation ("Give . . .") that is, indeed, the closing couplet.

The competitor might choose to address the speaker's request (lines 9-14) to eternize/to immortalize/ to memorialize the beauty of the person with whom the speaker is—or was—so infatuated.